



THE YOGA SENSEI · FREE GUIDE

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# Yoga for Beginners

## The Starter Guide

Everything you need to begin — the gear that's worth it, eight foundational poses, a 10-minute routine, and what to skip. No flexibility required.

# Your starter guide

## 01 What you actually need

The gear that's worth it — and what to skip

## 02 Eight poses to learn first

With photos, cues, and when to ease off

## 03 Your first 10-minute routine

A gentle morning flow + a 2-week rhythm

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Every claim, linked to read yourself

You don't need to be flexible, fit, or to buy anything to start yoga — just a clear bit of floor and ten quiet minutes. I'm Marvin; I've practised for years (not a certified instructor) and I write every word on The Yoga Sensei myself. This is what I'd tell a friend who asked how to begin. General guidance, not medical advice — check with your doctor if you have an injury, a condition, or you're pregnant.



# Almost nothing — but a good mat helps



You can start with no equipment at all. The one thing worth buying is a mat: a grippy surface stops your hands and feet sliding apart — the single most common beginner frustration. My picks, by budget:

## Gaiam Premium 6mm

BUDGET · CUSHIONED

Soft underfoot and cheap — the easiest first mat for most beginners.

[View on Amazon](#)

## Retrospec Solana ½"

BUDGET · EXTRA-THICK

Kind to sore knees and wrists on hard floors; a little less stable.

[View on Amazon](#)

## Jade Harmony

BEST GRIP · ECO

Natural rubber, superb dry grip. Contains latex — skip if allergic.

[View on Amazon](#)

## Liforme Original

PREMIUM · ALIGNMENT

A printed alignment guide on the surface for placing hands and feet.

[View on Amazon](#)

## Manduka PRO

BUY-IT-FOR-LIFE

Heavy, near-indestructible, lifetime guarantee; slippery until broken in.

[View on Amazon](#)

Full breakdown: [best yoga mats for beginners](#) · [how to choose a mat](#). Nice to have later (not now): two [blocks](#) and a [strap](#).

Some product links are affiliate links: if you buy through them I may earn a small commission, at no extra cost to you. I only list gear I'd actually use, researched from specs and real reviews — no invented lab tests.

# Eight poses to learn first

Learn these and you can follow almost any beginner class. Move slowly, breathe through your nose, and bend your knees freely — a long, straight back always beats straight legs.



## Mountain Pose

Tadasana

Stand tall, feet hip-width, weight even, crown lifting. The quiet base for every standing pose.

Ease off if: you feel light-headed — soften the knees.

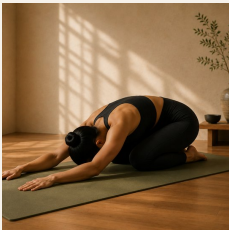


## Cat-Cow

Marjaryasana–Bitilasana

On hands and knees: inhale and arch, exhale and round. Warms the spine in under a minute.

Ease off if: your wrists complain — come to fists or forearms.



## Child's Pose

Balasana

Hips back toward the heels, arms forward, forehead down. Your rest button — return any time.

Ease off if: your knees hurt — widen them or add a cushion.

[Full guide](#)



## Downward Dog

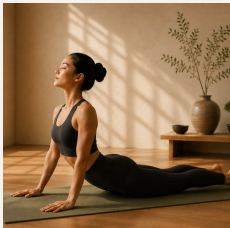
Adho Mukha Svanasana

Hips up and back into an inverted V. Bend the knees freely; the straight back is the goal.

Ease off if: wrists ache — press the floor away, share the load.

[Full guide](#)

# Eight poses to learn first



## Cobra

Bhujangasana

Lie on your front and lift the chest with the back muscles, hands light. A gentle backbend.

Ease off if: your lower back pinches — lift lower.

[Full guide](#)

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## Warrior II

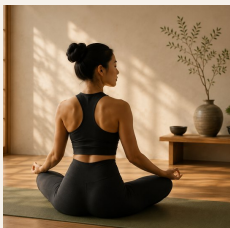
Virabhadrasana II

Step wide, turn one foot out, bend that knee over the ankle, reach the arms long. Strong and steady.

Ease off if: the front knee caves in — track it over the toes.

[Full guide](#)

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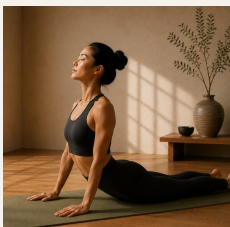


## Standing Forward Fold

Uttanasana

Hinge from the hips and fold over soft knees, head heavy. Releases the whole back of the body.

Ease off if: you feel dizzy rising — come up slowly.



## Sun Salutation A

Surya Namaskar A

The flowing sequence that links several of these poses, one breath per move. The heart of most classes.

Ease off if: you're rushing — slow the breath or do fewer rounds.

[Full guide](#)

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## A gentle 10-minute morning flow



Move slowly, one breath at a time, and skip anything that doesn't feel right first thing.

- 01 Child's Pose — settle and breathe (1 min)
- 02 Cat-Cow — warm the spine (1 min)
- 03 Downward Dog — wake the back body (5 breaths)
- 04 Standing Forward Fold — let the head hang (a few breaths)
- 05 One or two Sun Salutations — build gentle heat (2–3 min)
- 06 Cobra — open the chest (a few breaths)
- 07 Warrior II — energise, each side (a few breaths)
- 08 Seated twist, then rest — finish calm (1–2 min)

Full version with 5/15/30-minute options: [the morning yoga routine guide](#).

### A gentle two-week rhythm

**Week 1 — just show up.** Three short sessions; only the first four poses, 5–10 minutes. **Week 2 — add a little.** Three or four sessions of 10–15 minutes; add a Sun Salutation and Warrior II. **After that** — keep the 10-minute flow most mornings and explore new poses when curious.

## Five beginner mistakes

**Rushing the breath.** Let slow, nose breathing set the pace — not the other way around.

**Chasing flexibility.** You get flexible by practising; you don't need it to begin. Forcing a stretch is how people get hurt.

**Holding the breath.** It sneaks in the moment a pose gets hard. Keep it flowing and the pose eases.

**Comparing yourself.** To the person next to you, or to a video. Their body and years of practice aren't yours.

**Skipping the final rest.** Two quiet minutes at the end is where the practice settles. Don't cut it.

### When to take it easy

Yoga is generally safe when practised mindfully, but go gently, get a professional's eye, or skip poses if you have a recent injury, a back / neck / wrist / shoulder problem, uncontrolled high blood pressure, or you're pregnant. Sharp pain, dizziness, or pressure in the head are stop signals — come out of the pose. None of this is medical advice; when in doubt, ask your doctor.

## Sources & further reading

The research behind the health notes in this guide — all free to read:

**[NCCIH — Yoga: What You Need To Know](#)**

Plain-language overview of yoga, benefits and safety, from the US National Institutes of Health.

**[Pascoe et al. \(2017\) — Yoga & stress-related physiological measures](#)**

A meta-analysis: reviews link a regular practice to lower stress and cortisol; studies are small and mixed.

**[Bhavanani et al. — How effective is Sun Salutation \(24-week study\)](#)**

Students who practised Sun Salutations six days a week improved push-ups and sit-ups.

**[CDC — Physical Activity Guidelines for Adults](#)**

About 150 minutes of moderate movement a week; short daily sessions add up fast.

## Keep going — free on the site

- [Yoga for Beginners — the full guide](#)
- [Sun Salutation A — step by step](#)
- [Best yoga mats for beginners](#)

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— Marvin, The Yoga Sensei · [hello@theyogasensei.com](mailto:hello@theyogasensei.com)